Making a questions CSV

PATTS Exam Portal · instructor guide. A CSV is a spreadsheet saved as plain text. Make one in Excel or Google Sheets, one row per question, and the portal turns it into a paper.

1 Pick your kind of paper

Open the guide on the dashboard, choose what you are setting and download that example.

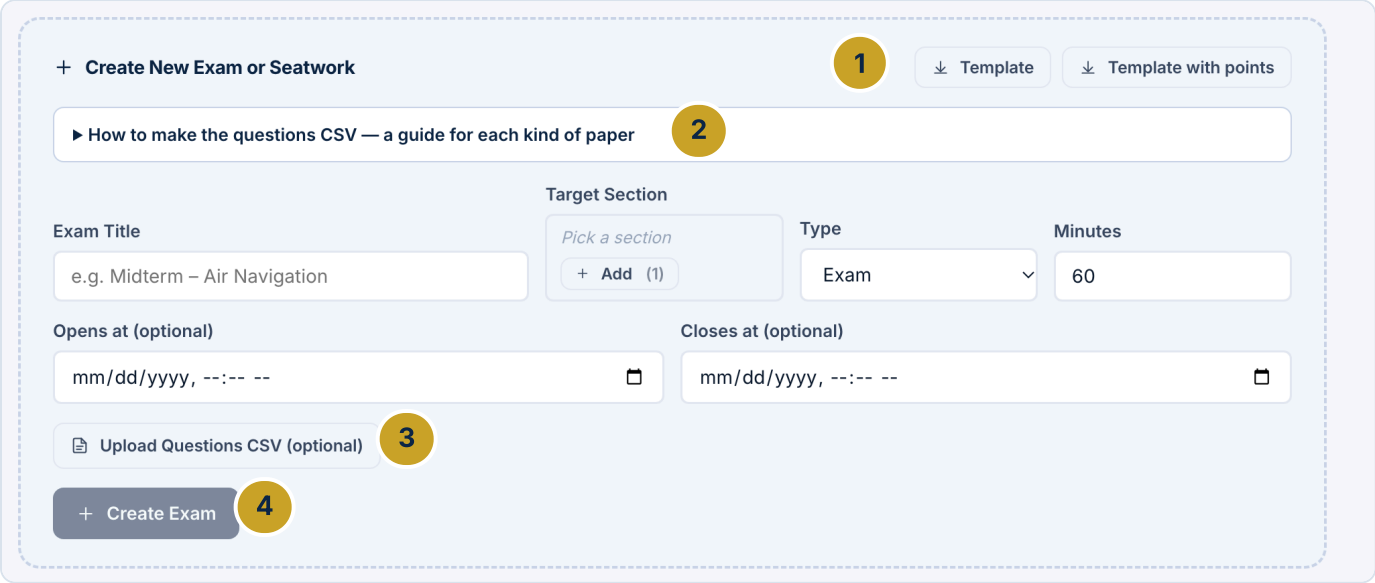
2 Fill in your rows

Replace the example rows with your questions. Keep the header row. Save as CSV.

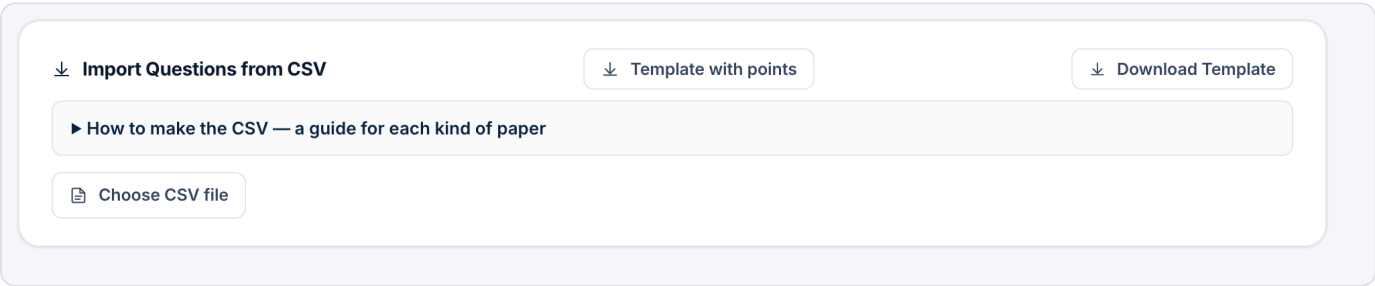
3 Upload and check

Choose the file. The portal shows what it read and any row it can't use before anything is saved.

Where to find it



Manage Exams → Create New Exam or Seatwork. ① Download a starter file. ② Open the guide for each kind of paper. ③ Upload your CSV. ④ Create the paper with its questions in one step.



Adding to a paper that already exists: Questions → choose the paper → Import Questions from CSV. Tick *Replace existing questions* only if the file should take the place of what is there.

What to put in the file, by kind of paper

Multiple choice

One right answer per question: a choice quiz, True/False, an identification with choices. Example file: template_multiple_choice.csv

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	**question_text**	**choice_a**	**choice_b**	**choice_c**	**choice_d**	**choice_e**	**correct_answer**
2	What is the primary function of the wing?	Produce lift	Produce thrust	Store fuel	Steer the aircraft		A
3	Which instrument shows altitude?	Airspeed indicator	Altimeter	Tachometer	Compass		B
4	Which of these is a primary flight control?	Flap	Slat	Spoiler	Trim tab	Aileron	E
5	An aerofoil produces lift by speeding up the air over its upper surface.	True	False				A

- One row per question. The question goes first and the answer goes in the last column.
- Give each question as many choices as it needs: 2 for True/False, 4, 5 or more. Leave unused choice cells empty.
- Write the answer as the letter of the right choice: `A`, `B`, `C`...
- Each student gets the questions and the choices in a different order, so avoid "All of the above", "Both A and B", or a question that refers to the one before it.

Several right answers

A question where the student ticks every correct choice. Example file: template_several_answers.csv

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	**question_text**	**choice_a**	**choice_b**	**choice_c**	**choice_d**	**choice_e**	**correct_answer**
2	Which of these are control surfaces?	Aileron	Elevator	Rudder	Flap	Fuel tank	A;B;C
3	Which forces act on an aircraft in straight and level flight?	Lift	Weight	Thrust	Drag	Torque	A;B;C;D
4	What is the primary function of the wing?	Produce lift	Produce thrust	Store fuel	Steer the aircraft		A

- Write every right letter in the answer cell, separated by semicolons: `A;B;C`.
- The semicolon is what turns the question into tick boxes. A single letter stays an ordinary one-answer question, so both kinds can share one file.
- The student earns the item only by ticking every right choice and no wrong one.

Essay

A written answer the student types in a box. Example file: template_essay.csv

	A	B	C	D
1	**question_text**	**choice_a**	**choice_b**	**correct_answer**
2	Explain in your own words how a wing produces lift.			
3	Describe two checks you would make on a control cable during an inspection.			

- Write the question and leave every choice cell and the answer empty.
- Essays are not marked automatically. You read each student's answer in their results.
- To make an essay worth more than one point, add a `points` column (see Points per item).

Points per item

A paper where some items are worth more than others, or that mixes kinds of question. Example file: template_points_per_item.csv

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	**question_text**	**type**	**points**	**answer**	**choice_a**	**choice_b**	**choice_c**	**choice_d**
2	What is the primary function of the wing?	mc	1	A	Produce lift	Produce thrust	Store fuel	Steer the aircraft
3	Which of these are control surfaces?	multi	3	A;B	Aileron	Elevator	Flap	Fuel tank
4	Explain in your own words how a wing produces lift.	essay	10					

- Adding a `points` or `type` column to the header row switches the file to named columns. The columns can then come in any order, and the answer goes in the `answer` column instead of the last one.
- `points` is a whole number from 1 to 100. A blank cell counts as 1.
- `type` is one of `mc`, `multi`, `essay`, `math` or `quantity`. You can leave it blank and it is worked out from the row.
- Any column the guide doesn't name counts as a choice, so you can keep calling them `choice_a`, `choice_b` ...

Maths answer

The student types the final answer with the maths keyboard: limits, derivatives, integrals, simplifying.

Example file: template_maths.csv

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	**question_text**	**type**	**points**	**given**	**answer**	**accept**
2	Evaluate the limit.	math	2	\lim_{x\to 3}(2x+1)	7	
3	Differentiate with respect to x.	math	3	y=x^3	y'=3x^2	
4	Differentiate with respect to x.	math	3	y=\ln(x)	y'=\frac{1}{x}	y'=x^{-1}
5	Evaluate the integral.	math	4	y=\int 4x\,dx	y=2x^2+C	y=2x^2+K

- `given` is the problem the student starts from, written in LaTeX. `answer` is the simplified result.
- The answer is marked automatically the moment the student submits.
- Spacing, `\cdot`, braces, a `y'=` in front, and `2` against `2.0` or `0.5` against `\frac{1}{2}` all match automatically.
- Use `accept` only for a form that needs algebra to see as equal, such as `x^{-1}` for `\frac{1}{x}`. Separate several with semicolons.
- A maths item from a CSV is all or nothing. To give marks for each step, build the question in the editor instead.
- In Excel, a cell that starts with `=`, `+` or `-` is read as a formula. Type an apostrophe first (`'-x^2+C`). The apostrophe is not saved.

Number with unit

A computed answer typed as a value and its unit, e.g. 2.67 m/s. Example file: template_number_with_unit.csv

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	**question_text**	**type**	**points**	**given**	**answer**	**accept**
2	Air flows through a duct at 0.8 kg/s with a density of 1.2 kg/m^3 and an area of 0.25 m^2. Find the velocity.	quantity	4	Velocity V	2.67 m/s	m/sec;meters per second
3	A runway is 2.4 km long. Find its length in metres.	quantity	2	Runway length (nearest whole number)	2,400 m	meters;metres
4	An aircraft flies at 250 m/s where the speed of sound is 340 m/s. Find its Mach number.	quantity	2	Mach number	0.7353	

- One row per part. `given` names the part, and the student sees it with its rounding: "a) Velocity V (2 decimal places)".
- Write `answer` as the number, then the unit. The decimals in your answer set how far students round: `2.67` takes `2.67` or `2.6667`.
- Half the points are for the number and half for the unit, with an odd point going to the number. An answer with no unit puts every point on the number.
- Capitals, spaces, "per" for "/", and plurals already match. In `accept`, list only genuinely different spellings of the unit, separated by semicolons.
- Excel drops trailing zeros: a unitless `0.7350` becomes `0.735` and changes the rounding. Format that column as Text before typing.

Sets A–H

One paper in several versions, each set with its own numbers, plus items every set shares. Example file: template_sets.csv

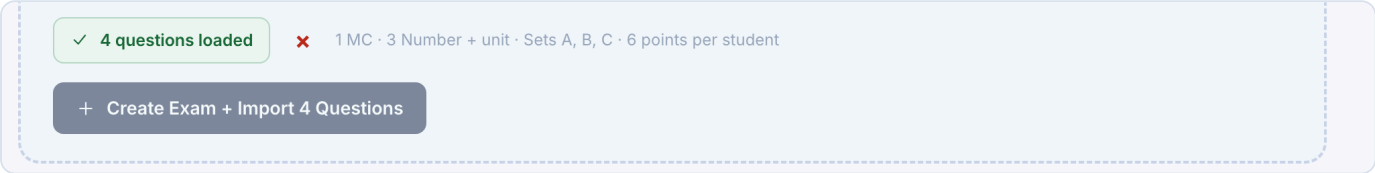
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I
1	**question_text**	**set**	**type**	**points**	**given**	**answer**	**choice_a**	**choice_b**	**choice_c**
2	Which instrument shows altitude?		mc	2		B	Airspeed indicator	Altimeter	Compass
3	Air flows through a duct at 0.8 kg/s with a density of 1.2 kg/m^3 and an area of 0.25 m^2. Find the velocity.	A	quantity	4	Velocity V	2.67 m/s			
4	Air flows through a duct at 0.9 kg/s with a density of 1.2 kg/m^3 and an area of 0.25 m^2. Find the velocity.	B	quantity	4	Velocity V	3.00 m/s			
5	Air flows through a duct at 1.2 kg/s with a density of 1.2 kg/m^3 and an area of 0.25 m^2. Find the velocity.	C	quantity	4	Velocity V	4.00 m/s			

- Put a letter in the `set` column (`A` to `H`, or any letter) to put the row in that set only. Leave it blank for an item every set gets.
- Students see one Start button per set. Tell each student which set to press.
- Each student is marked only on their own set plus the shared items, so give every set the same number of items and points.
- The `set` column works with every kind of question: choices, maths, number with unit and essay.

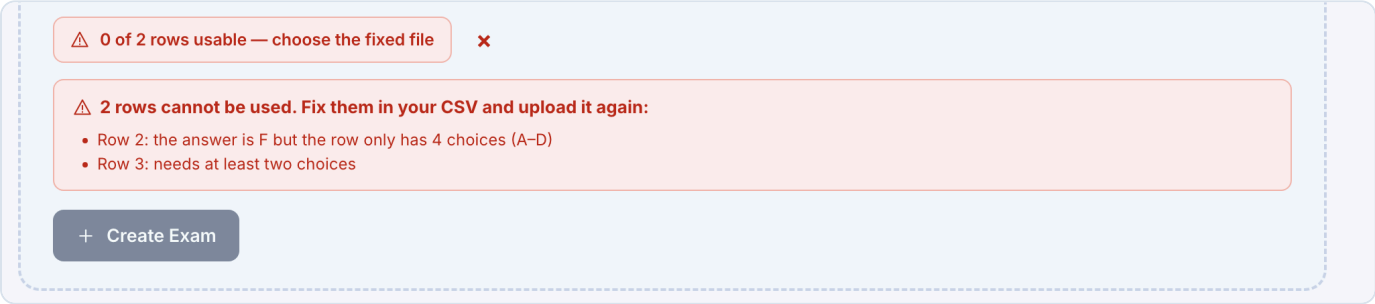
For every file

- Keep the header row as the first line. It tells the portal what each column is.
- In Excel use File → Save As → CSV UTF-8. In Google Sheets use File → Download → Comma-separated values.
- A cell with a comma in it needs quotes around it. Excel and Google Sheets add them for you.
- To start a new line inside a question, type `<br>` where the line should break, or press Alt+Enter in an Excel cell (Option+Enter on a Mac, Ctrl+Enter in Google Sheets).
- After you choose the file, the portal says how many questions it read and lists any problem by row number. Nothing is saved until you confirm.

Upload and check



A good file: how many questions were read, what kinds, and the points. On a paper in sets it gives the points one student sits.



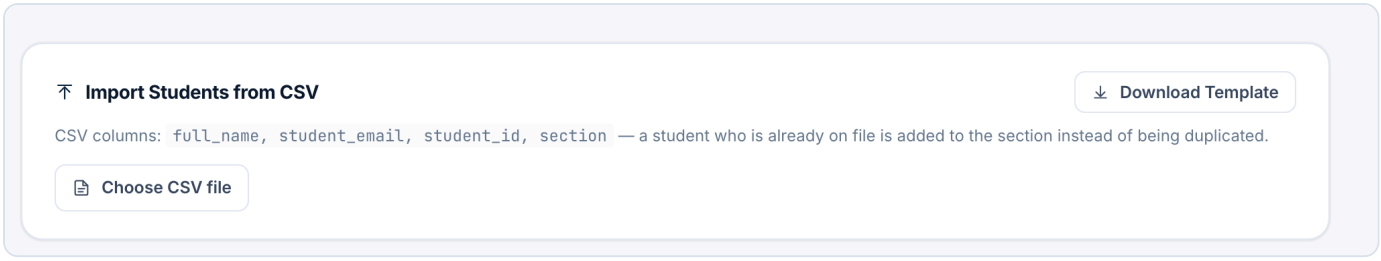
A file with problems: each row that can't be used is listed with its row number and the reason. Fix those rows in the spreadsheet, save, and choose the file again.

Student roster CSV

Students → Import Students from CSV. Four columns, in this order, every one filled in:

	A	B	C	D
1	**full_name**	**student_email**	**student_id**	**section**
2	Juan dela Cruz	juan.delacruz@patts.edu.ph	2021-1-1234	Aero 101
3	Maria Santos	maria.santos@patts.edu.ph	2021-1-5678	Aero 101
4	Pedro Reyes	pedro.reyes@patts.edu.ph	2022-2-9012	Aero 102

- `student_id` is what the student types to sign in. Check it against their ID.
- A student already on file is **added to the section**, not duplicated. To put one student in two of your sections, give them two rows.
- Sections are shared with other instructors, so an import only ever adds your sections. It never removes another instructor's.



The questions, names and emails in this guide are examples for illustration only.